

IK 524: Introduction to Indian Architecture

Course Code	IK 524
Course Name	Introduction to Indian Architecture
L-T-P-C	3-0-0-3
Prerequisites	None
Intended for	B.Tech/MTech/MS/MSc/MA/PhD
Mutual Exclusion	There are no equivalent or overlapping courses across schools.
Approval	64th BoA (May 2026)

Preamble

This course is designed in strict accordance with Unit 5 (Architecture) of the official UGC NET Indian Knowledge System (IKS) Code 103 syllabus. The course introduces the architectural traditions of ancient and medieval India including urban planning traditions of the Indus Valley Civilization, Hindu temple architecture, Buddhist and Jaina architectural traditions, rock-cut cave architecture, Himalayan temple traditions, Sun temples, water harvesting systems, and the fundamentals of Vāstu Śāstra.

The course systematically examines the architectural, cultural, civilizational, and spiritual dimensions of Indian architecture through the study of major temples, monuments, sacred spaces, urban systems, and water management traditions across different regions of India. Particular emphasis is placed on Nāgara, Drāviḍa, and Vesarā temple styles, architectural symbolism, regional diversity, sacred geography, and traditional Indian ecological approaches to settlement and construction.

The course is research-oriented and emphasizes analytical learning through architectural interpretation, historical understanding, comparative stylistic analysis, and interdisciplinary engagement with Indian architectural knowledge systems.

Course Modules

- Module 1: Indus Valley Civilization and Foundations of Indian Architecture:** Indus Valley Civilization, urban planning traditions, Dholavira, foundations of ancient Indian settlement planning, introduction to sacred architecture and civilizational planning traditions in India. (Weeks 1–2)
- Module 2: Hindu Temple Architecture and Architectural Styles:** Elementary concepts of Nāgara style temples, Drāviḍa style temples, and Vesarā style temples, structural and symbolic elements of Hindu temple architecture, regional variations in temple traditions, introduction to temple planning and sacred spatial organization. (Weeks 3–4)
- Module 3: Buddhist, Jaina, Rock-cut and Himalayan Temple Traditions:** Buddhist and Jaina temples including Udayagiri, Sanchi, Sarnath, and Nalanda; rock and cave temples including Elephanta, Jageshvari, Ajanta, and Ellora; Himalayan temples including Kedarnath, Tungamatha, Jageshvara, and Baleshvara; elementary knowledge of architectural style, historical period, and presiding deities associated with these traditions. (Weeks 5–7)
- Module 4: Ancient and Medieval Temple Traditions of India:** Mundeshwari Devi Temple, Daśavatāra Viṣṇu Temple, Deogarh, Khajuraho Temples, Liṅgarāja Temple (Bhubaneswar), Ṭerakoṭā Temple (Viṣṇupura), temples of Bādāmī and Aihole (Cālukyāna temples), Kāñcī and Mahābalīpuram temples, Cōla temples, Sun temples of Kōṇārka, Mōḍhērā, Kaṭāramala (Almora), and Mārtaṇḍa (Anantanag), including elementary knowledge of architectural style, historical period, and presiding deities. (Weeks 8–10)
- Module 5: Ancient Indian Water Storage and Harvesting Systems:** Ancient and medieval Indian water storage and harvesting systems including Kallanai Dam, Aḍalāja Stepwell, Tārikā techniques of Rajasthan, and Āhāra-Pāina systems of Bihar; ecological knowledge systems and sustainable architectural traditions in India. (Weeks 11–12)
- Module 6: Fundamentals of Vāstu Śāstra and Contemporary Relevance:** Fundamentals of Vāstu Śāstra, elementary concepts of spatial harmony and traditional Indian architectural principles, relation between architecture, sacred space, ecology, environment, ritual, and wellbeing, contemporary relevance of Indian architectural knowledge systems. (Weeks 13–14)

Text Books

- Acharya, P. K. *Architecture of Manasara*, Oxford University Press.
- Brown, Percy. *Indian Architecture: Buddhist and Hindu Periods*, D.B. Taraporevala Sons & Co.

References

- Stella Kramrisch. *The Hindu Temple*, Motilal Banarsidass.
- Dagens, Bruno. *Mayamata: An Indian Treatise on Housing, Architecture and Iconography*.
- Michell, George. *The Hindu Temple: An Introduction to Its Meaning and Forms*.
- Vāstuśāstra texts and temple architectural manuals.
- Studies on Dholavira and Indus Valley urban planning traditions.
- Research studies on Ajanta, Ellora, Khajuraho, and Konark temples.
- Literature on Indian water harvesting systems and sacred architecture traditions.